Guide · W-Seminar "Time"

From Topic to Thesis: A W-Seminar Research Guide

Theme: *Time, in all its facets* | Developing your research question, working thesis and thesis statement

A successful W-Seminar paper (*Seminararbeit*) follows a clear intellectual arc: your **research question** is the compass that guides your investigation, and your **thesis statement** is the evidence-based answer you reach after exploring the literature – and, if you collect them, your own data. In between, your claim grows: first as a **working thesis**, then as a **testable claim** (W4–W7: box *My question – version n*).



Step 1: Craft the Research Question

the starting point · spark question → research question · W2–W4

A research question narrows the vast theme of *Time* into an academic problem you can realistically investigate in 10–15 pages. Start with curiosity, not a fixed opinion – your first *spark question* may be rough.

1. **Choose a facet of "time":** one disciplinary angle – physics, biology, psychology, history, literature, language …
2. **Narrow the scope:** restrict your topic by *population*, *historical era*, *medium*, *material or specific variables*.
3. **Use open-ended interrogatives:** *How*, *Why*, *To what extent*, *In what ways*. Avoid simple yes/no questions.
4. **Ask one question at a time:** if your question contains an "and", check whether it hides two.

Weak (yes/no): Does social media change how teenagers experience time?

Better (open – but still two questions, and very wide): To what extent does short-form video consumption alter time perception and attention span among adolescents?

Strong (open, focused, researchable): *To what extent does watching short videos for ten minutes change how long Year 10 students think a following task took?*

Check your question: the six markers – or FINER

Before committing to a question, check it against the six markers you know from W4:

Focused	Who or what exactly, where, when?
Open	No yes/no, no either/or.
Researchable	Do sources exist that you can get and read?
Testable	Could a result answer it – either way?
Feasible	10–15 pages, by the deadline, with your means?
Relevant	Does someone want to know the answer?

The same idea, another name: FINER. Research guides often use this checklist:

Feasible – sources, time → feasible, researchable
Interesting – to you and others → relevant
Novel – a fresh angle → relevant
Ethical – consent, permission → feasible
Relevant – connected to *Time* → relevant

FINER takes for granted what our markers spell out: *focused*, *open*, *testable*.

Step 2: Conduct Preliminary Research

the bridge · W5

Before formulating a thesis, survey existing scholarship, historical sources or scientific studies.

- **Map the debate:** identify key concepts, competing theories and unresolved questions in your facet of time – and which methods others used.
- **Ask your refinery questions** (W5): what must be defined, explained, put into context, tested and evaluated so that your thesis can stand?
- **Follow the evidence:** let credible sources shape your claim rather than cherry-picking quotes to fit a preconceived opinion. Note what speaks *against* your idea, too.
- **Few sources?** Look at neighbouring fields, the primary material itself – or ask an expert (M3).

Step 3: Write the Working Thesis

your first answer · research question → working thesis · W4–W5

Your thesis statement is a concise, one-to-two-sentence central claim that directly answers your research question; it acts as an argumentative roadmap for your reader. As long as your research is still running, it is your **working thesis**: your best answer so far. A simple start: write "I expect that … because …" – then delete "I expect that".

Reliable formula: [specific subject] + [debatable claim] + [because of key supporting reasons]

The reasons must be something your paper actually examines. *"… because it aligns class schedules with delayed melatonin release"* – you cannot measure melatonin; *"… because students sleep longer"* – that you can ask. The deeper mechanism belongs in your discussion, backed by sources.

A good working thesis **answers** the question directly, is **arguable** (not a fact, not a taste), **specific** (group, material, direction), **testable** (a result could prove it wrong) and **short**.

Step 4: Make It Testable

the claim meets the evidence · working thesis → testable claim · W6–W7

A thesis is only as good as the evidence you can actually get – match your claim to it. With your own data (survey, test, experiment) it becomes a *hypothesis* with variables. Always note which result would prove you wrong.

Examples across facets of "time"

Facet	Research question	Working thesis	Tested with
Chronobiology	How does a later school start affect how long Year 11 students sleep on school nights?	Starting school one hour later lengthens school-night sleep, because adolescents' sleep phase shifts later.	own data: survey at two schools with different start times
History	How did local communities in 19th-century Germany respond to standardised railway time?	Resistance to railway time was not merely technical conservatism: it replaced local and religious timekeeping with industrial and state control.	historical sources: newspapers, petitions, council records
Literature	How does non-linear narrative structure in modernist fiction reflect subjective memory?	Non-linear structures mirror memory by ordering scenes by emotional association rather than chronology – psychological time outweighs clock time.	close reading and coding of scene order in two novels
Psychology	To what extent does the feeling that time speeds up with age depend on how it is measured?	The age effect appears when people look back over years, not when they judge the present.	studies as data: 14 published studies, grouped by measure

Choose the option that fits you

Of your one to three options (W4), prefer the one where you can say *yes* to most of these: I will still care about it in ten months · I can get and read the sources · the evidence is within reach – own data, studies or texts · it suits my skills (statistics, close reading, languages, Python …) · I know which result would prove it wrong · it fits 10–15 pages. If one is a clear *no*, fix that point first – or drop the option.

Key Rules for a Strong W-Seminar Paper

testable claim → thesis statement · the paper

- **It must be arguable:** a thesis cannot be an undisputed fact (*"Einstein developed the theory of relativity"*). Another researcher must be able to examine the same evidence and debate your interpretation.
- **It must be specific:** replace vague claims like *"Time plays an important role in society"* with exact mechanisms, texts or variables.
- **It must be testable:** a claim no result could contradict is a belief; a wish (*"Schools should start later"*) needs a claim behind it.
- **Expect evolution:** treat your claim as a working thesis and refine it version by version (W4–W7: *what changed – and why?*) – a hallmark of strong academic work. The **thesis statement** comes last, after your results: it opens your introduction and answers your question in the conclusion. If the data do not support your working thesis, that is a result, too – report it and discuss why.

Example: one question, six versions (as in the worksheet solutions)

version	question / claim	what changed – and why
0 · W2 spark	Why do waits feel so long?	curiosity, no focus yet
1 · W4	Does music change how long a wait feels? – *Music makes waits feel shorter.*	a focus – but still yes/no
2 · W5	How does the tempo of background music change how long a wait feels? – *With fast music, a 3-minute wait feels shorter than with slow music.*	sources: the tempo matters, not music as such
3 · W6	*Fast music (140 bpm) leads to lower estimates of a 3-minute wait, in minutes, than slow music (60 bpm).*	made measurable: fixed wait, two tempos, a unit
4 · W7	same claim; two clearly different tempos, about 64 students per group	pilot: tempos felt too similar, too few people
the paper	*For teenagers, fast background music makes a 3-minute wait feel almost half a minute shorter than slow music.*	thesis statement, backed by the results (d = 0.73)